Social, Ethical, and Professional Issues in Computing

القضايا الاجتماعية والأخلاقية والمهنية في الحوسبة

Chapter 1
An Overview of Ethics

Objectives

- As you read this chapter, consider the following questions:
  - What is ethics, and why is it important to act according to a code of ethics?
  - Why is business ethics becoming increasingly important?
  - What are organizations doing to improve their business ethics?

Objectives (cont'd.)

- Why are organizations interested in fostering good business ethics?
- What approach can you take to ensure ethical decision making?
- What trends have increased the risk of using information technology in an unethical manner?

Morals الأخلاق

- One's personal beliefs about right and wrong
- Morality may vary by:
  - Age
  - Cultural group
  - Ethnic background
  - Religion
  - Life experiences
  - Education
  - Gender

Definition of Ethics

- Ethics
  - Set of beliefs about right and wrong behavior within a society
- Virtues فضائل
  - Habits that incline people to do what is acceptableالعادات التي تدفع الناس إلى فعل ما هو مقبول
- Vices الرذائل
  - Habits of unacceptable behavior
- Virtues and vices define a personal value system
  - Scheme of moral values

The Difference Between Morals, Ethics, and Laws

- Morals: one's personal beliefs about right and wrong
- Ethics: standards or codes of behavior expected of an individual by a group
- Law: system of rules that tells us what we can and cannot do
  - Laws are enforced by a set of institutions
  - Legal acts conform to the law
  - Moral acts conform to what an individual believes is the right belief of right and wrong

The Importance of Integrity

- Integrity (امتلاك المبادئ الأخلاقية) is a cornerstone of ethical behavior
- People with integrity:
  - Act in accordance with a personal code of principles
  - Extend to all the same respect and consideration
  - Apply the same moral standards in all situations
- Lack of integrity emerges if you apply moral standards differently according to situation or people involved
- Many ethical dilemmas are not as simple as right versus wrong

Ethics in the Business World

- Both the likelihood and the negative impact of inappropriate behavior have increased
- Several trends have increased the likelihood of unethical behavior:
  - Globalization creating complex work environments
  - Organizations challenged to maintain profits / revenue
  - Heightened vigilance by:
    - Employees
    - Shareholders
    - Regulatory agencies

Ethics in the Business World (cont'd.)

- Recent scandals in IT companies
  - Computer Associates International
  - IBM
- Not just executives, but even lower-level employees, can find themselves in the middle of an ethical dilemma

Ethics in the Business World (cont'd.)

Most common forms of employee misconduct:

- Misuse of company time
- Lying to employees
- Company resource abuse
- Lying to outside stakeholders
- Falsifying time reports or hours worked

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR)

المسؤولية الاجتماعية للشركات

- Organization taking responsibility for the impact of its actions on the:
  - Environment
  - Community
  - Welfare of its employees

Why Fostering Good Business Ethics Is Important

لماذا يُعد تعزيز أخلاقيات العمل الجيدة أمراً مهماً؟

- To gain the good will of the community
- To create an organization that operates consistently
- To foster good business practices
- To protect organization/employees from legal action
- To avoid unfavorable publicity (الدعاية السلبية)

1. Gaining the Good Will of the Community

- Organizations have fundamental responsibilities to society
  - Include:
    - Making contributions to charitable organizations and nonprofit institutions
    - Providing benefits for employees in excess of legal requirements
    - Choosing economic opportunities that might be more socially desirable than profitable
- Socially responsible activities create good will which makes it easier for corporations to conduct business

2. Creating an Organization That Operates Consistently

- Consistency ensures that employees:
  - Know what is expected of them
  - Can employ the organization's values to help them in decision making
- Consistency also means that shareholders, customers, suppliers, and community know what they can expect of the organization

Creating an Organization That Operates Consistently (cont'd.)

- Many companies share the following values:
  - Operate with honesty and integrity, staying true to organizational principles
  - Operate according to standards of ethical conduct, in words and action
  - Treat colleagues, customers, and consumers with respect
  - Strive to be the best at what matters to the company
  - Value diversity
  - Make decisions based on facts and principles

3. Fostering Good Business Practices

- Good ethics means good business/improved profits
- Companies that:
  - Produce safe and effective products
    - Avoid costly recalls and lawsuits
  - Provide excellent service that retains customers
  - Develop and maintain strong employee relations

Fostering Good Business Practices (cont'd.)

- Suppliers/business partners place priority on working with companies that operate in a fair and ethical manner
- Bad ethics means bad business/waning profits
  - Bad ethics can lead to bad business results
  - Bad ethics can have a negative impact on employees

4. Protecting the Organization and Its Employees from Legal Actions

- An employer can be held responsible for the acts of its employees (Respondeat Superior)
- Union of several legal organizations argues that the establishment of ethics programs should reduce criminal responsibility of organization

5. Avoiding Unfavorable Publicity

- Public reputation of company strongly influences:
  - Value of its stock
  - How consumers regard products and services
  - Degree of oversight received from government
  - Amount of support and cooperation received
- Organizations are motivated to build strong ethics programs to avoid negative publicity